

Chapter 178 Part 1: Extra Story 1-1

The year Xu Qingzhu gave birth to Chaochao and Mumu, and before Chaochao and Mumu turned two years old, Liang Shi took on very little work.

She basically turned down all dramas, except for those filmed near Haizhou City where she could return home every day—she didn't accept any others.

To her, family was more important than work.

She already felt guilty about not being able to share the burden of childbirth with Xu Qingzhu, so she could only try to make up for it after the two little ones were born by giving Xu Qingzhu enough space for work and life.

But the two little ones were still more attached to Xu Qingzhu.

Especially Shen Xuan.

So much so that when Xu Qingzhu occasionally held video meetings in the study, crying would often be heard from the room, or after Shen Xuan learned to walk, she would suddenly appear in Xu Qingzhu's video frame without warning, greatly distracting everyone's attention.

Sometimes when Xu Qingzhu was in a particularly important meeting, she would lock the door. Shen Xuan would then sneak to the study door when Liang Shi wasn't paying attention, first patting with one small hand, calling out in a milky voice: "Mommy~ open the door."

Xu Qingzhu was especially sensitive to their voices. Even while wearing earphones in a meeting, she would instantly recognize their voices and would get distracted for half a second to send Liang Shi a message: 【SOS! Your daughter is here again!】

After Liang Shi received the message, she would immediately rush to the study door.

Thus, Xu Qingzhu's ears would receive dual audio channels.

One ear had staff members reporting the situation, while the other ear without the earphone would hear Liang Shi and Shen Xuan's voices.

Liang Shi would lower her voice to coax: "Baby, come back to the room with Mama. Mommy is working, we can't disturb her, okay~"

When talking to children, she would always use sentence-final particles.¹

And it was even more excessive than when she used to talk to Ling Dang and the others.

Xu Qingzhu, as someone who especially loved hearing Liang Shi speak in a soft voice, sometimes couldn't stand it.

But the children loved it.

Even their children, who knew whom they took after, were each better at acting cute than the last!

Even through the door, Xu Qingzhu could imagine Shen Xuan's expression—she must be pouting, looking at Liang Shi with an aggrieved expression, blinking at her with eyelashes that were long and dense, curled and upturned.

Both daughters inherited Liang Shi's eyes, both having light brown pupils, but the eye shape was exactly the same as Xu Qingzhu's.

They had completely inherited the best features of both.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu were already considered good-looking.

But the two little ones showed signs of surpassing their parents.²

So when they acted cute, it was especially irresistible.

"Mama." Shen Xuan would extend her milky-white little hand, tugging at Liang Shi's hem, "Just one look~ pretty please?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"How about waiting until Mommy finishes her meeting before looking, okay?" Liang Shi tried to negotiate with her.

Shen Xuan continued tugging at her hem, acting cute, "Wuwuwu~"

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi would keep making "shh" gestures at her, but this trick obviously didn't work.

At this point, Chaochao would walk over, furrowing her brow despite her young age: "Please, can you be more obedient."

Shen Xuan huffed: "No!"

Chaochao sighed: "Mama, you really can't keep spoiling her!"

"Of course Mama has to spoil me! I'm her little cutie!" Shen Xuan put her hands on her hips, "Hmph!"

Chaochao looked at Liang Shi and asked seriously: "Mama, you said I was your only little cutie."

Liang Shi: "....."

SOS!

And so what started as Shen Xuan looking for Mommy evolved into the two little ones competing for affection, each one tugging at one of Liang Shi's arms, swaying Liang Shi back and forth.

Afraid of disturbing Xu Qingzhu, Liang Shi picked one up in each arm and went back to the bedroom.

The two little ones continued competing for affection.

Chaochao: "Mama, tell me, who is your favorite baby?"

Mumu: "It's definitely me!"

Chaochao: "No, Mama said it was me last time!"

Mumu: "Then Mommy's favorite must be me!"

Liang Shi put them both on the bed, was silent for two seconds, then answered seriously and firmly: "Your Mommy's favorite person is me."

Chaochao & Mumu: "?"

After saying this, Liang Shi suddenly felt a bit embarrassed—competing for affection with two kids was beneath her dignity!

Especially since these two were her own daughters.

Just as she was about to say something to make up for it, she heard a low laugh from behind.

Xu Qingzhu had been so disrupted by Shen Xuan that she couldn't continue the meeting, so she had to end it early. Then she came over and heard their conversation.

She couldn't help but laugh.

When Liang Shi turned around, she saw a smiling face. Shen Xuan immediately ran over to hug her leg, her chubby little face pressed against Xu Qingzhu's leg and rubbing against it, her milky voice soft and sweet, drawing out the tone: "Mommy~ I missed you so much!"

"I only left for ten minutes." Xu Qingzhu bent down and pinched her face, "If you don't listen to Mama again next time, I'll spank you."

Xu Qingzhu deliberately put on a stern face, but Shen Xuan wasn't scared at all. "I just missed you, what did I do wrong?"

Liang Shi: "?"

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

A few seconds later, Xu Qingzhu asked Liang Shi: "What have you been showing her?"

Liang Shi: ".....Nothing at all!"

Chaochao tattled from the side, "Mama was looking at a script earlier and read some lines out loud."

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu were simultaneously speechless.

Liang Shi shook her head, both helpless and stunned: "No wonder that line sounded so familiar."

Xu Qingzhu also poked Shen Xuan's head, "So young yet so cunning."³

Shen Xuan corrected her matter-of-factly: "Mommy, the phrase is 'mischievously clever.'"⁴

Children under five always managed to say surprising things.

The younger sister was more lively than the older sister, and also more mischievous.

Even though they were identical twins and looked very similar, when taken out, you could almost tell at a glance which one was the older sister and which one was the younger sister.

Chaochao always gave off a feeling of being more mature than her peers.

Liang Shi felt it was like how Rainbow initially made her feel.

Except she was better at acting cute than Rainbow.

She even specifically asked Zhou Li what Rainbow was like at this age.

What Zhou Li described was almost exactly like Chaochao's current situation.

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1. In Chinese, "语气词" (yǔqì cí) refers to sentence-final particles that convey tone or emotion, such as "呀," "啊," "哦," "嘛," etc. These particles soften speech and add emotional nuance, commonly used when speaking affectionately or to children. ⇐
 2. The original phrase "青出于藍勝于藍" (qīng chū yú lán shèng yú lán) is a Chinese idiom meaning "the student surpasses the master" or literally "blue comes from indigo but is bluer than indigo." Here it means the children are even more beautiful than their already good-looking parents. ⇐
 3. The original phrase "人小鬼大" (rén xiǎo guǐ dà) literally means "small person, big ghost/demon" and is used to describe a child who is young but surprisingly clever, cunning, or street-smart beyond their years. ⇐
 4. The phrase "古靈精怪" (gǔ líng jīng guài) means mischievously clever or quirky in an endearing way, with more positive connotations than the previous phrase. ⇐

Chapter 178 Part 2: Extra Story 1-2

Back then, Liang Shi had thought Rainbow had lost the joys of childhood, but unexpectedly, her own daughter—even when someone wanted to play with her, she wouldn't play.

Occasionally when Liang Shi watched science fiction movies, she would watch along too.

If it were Mumu, she couldn't watch them at all and would only fuss about wanting to watch the story of two little red pandas.

Yes, the cartoons had already changed from the little rabbits that Ling Dang and the others used to watch to little red pandas.

Liang Shi bought them lots of fairy tale books. Chaochao wasn't interested at all, and Mumu wasn't interested either because there were too many words—she wanted to look at ones with pictures.

Liang Shi was even so worried about this that she couldn't sleep for several nights, and went to see Dr. Gu for psychological counseling.

Dr. Gu said this was a normal phenomenon and only indicated that Chaochao had a higher IQ.

So they could only let nature take its course.

With the two children making a ruckus at home, time flew by quickly.

It wasn't until they sent the two of them to kindergarten that Liang Shi began to focus on preparing to film.

She had previously been in two TV dramas with pretty good reputations—one was "Afterglow" in collaboration with Zhao Ying, and the other was "Sharp Edge," Gu Yixue's first time filming a TV drama, with the script co-written by Gu Yixue and Gu Xingyue.

There was also a movie called "Journey of the Heart" that was considered a minor hit, which had even been nominated for Best Actress. Unfortunately, due to the fierce competition that year, she regrettably didn't win.

But it was still considered recognition from the industry.

"Sharp Edge" had been a double success in both reputation and ratings at the time, even sparking a domestic suspense craze.

For an entire year, all major platforms were promoting suspense dramas. Gu Xingyue's "Blade" also triggered another wave in domestic suspense novels, and she became a highly sought-after suspense writer for a time.

Unfortunately, "Blade" touched on deeper social issues, making it difficult to pass censorship review,¹ so it was never filmed.

"Sharp Edge" was also nominated for Best Actress at the country's highest television awards. Liang Shi won the TV Queen title² with her superb acting skills. Afterward, she continued to film some dramas and movies one after another, but none were lead roles.

They were all supporting roles that felt pretty good, and she even won a Best Supporting Actress award.

However, these were all television awards.

Liang Shi had filmed fewer works in the past two years, but she had been continuously filming and continuously releasing them, never completely disappearing from the public eye.

She had also left behind quite a few memorable supporting characters.

Even so, what was more recognized domestically was still the film market.

The first project Liang Shi filmed after her return was a movie, in collaboration with Yang Shuyan, called "You in My Memory," which told the story of Alzheimer's disease.

The process of landing this role was also very difficult.

Because this role had a large time span, going from age 20 to 70, with elderly makeup accounting for half of the time.

Originally, the director didn't want to use this kind of new generation actor, but when casting was open to the entire society, the other roles were quickly decided—only the female lead role couldn't be settled.

Liang Shi had her eye on this script and also wanted to challenge herself again, so on the day of the audition, she went wearing elderly makeup.

In order to better portray the demeanor of elderly people and the daily life of those with Alzheimer's disease, Liang Shi spent an entire month—after dropping Chaochao and Mumu off at kindergarten—staying at a nursing home, specifically spending time with an elderly person who had Alzheimer's disease.

On the first day she went, Liang Shi and she chatted happily, introducing themselves.

On the second day she went, the elderly woman wouldn't remember Liang Shi.

Or sometimes she would remember on the second day, then forget after several days.

When her relatives came to visit her, they were always forgotten too, yet she would remember things from a very long time ago.

She would become forgetful, become melancholic, forgetting her growth in the process of growing old.

So when auditioning for the elderly scenes, Liang Shi moved the director.

In the end, the director chose her.

Yang Shuyan played a single mother in the movie.

If they had to rank billing, Yang Shuyan was first, because the story revolved around Yang Shuyan's character, but it would intersperse flashbacks, making it also a story about the inheritance of familial love.

The film happened to need a child actor.

Liang Shi had never thought of using her own daughter. The director's side had also selected a rather talented child actor, but two days after filming began, when it was time to film the child actor's scenes, the child actor who had been temporarily arranged couldn't come because she had fallen at school, hit her head on the steps, and gotten three stitches.

That day, Liang Shi and Yang Shuyan had evening scenes, so Xu Qingzhu brought the two little ones to visit the set.

The mischievous and active Mumu took advantage of Xu Qingzhu's inattention and ran around the set as if having the time of her life, and was spotted by the director.

The director held onto her and excitedly shouted on set: "Whose child is this?"

Liang Shi, who was rehearsing with Yang Shuyan, glanced over and was terrified, thinking Mumu had caused some trouble. She immediately ran over to grab her, "What happened?"

Mumu stared with her big eyes: "Mama!"

And so, through Mumu's self-recommendation, Liang Shi played her... grandmother.

For quite a long time afterward, Mumu would call out regardless of time or place: "Grandma~"

Liang Shi: "....."

The most ridiculous thing was one weekend after filming wrapped, when she and Xu Qingzhu took the two kids to eat at KFC. Liang Shi took Mumu to the counter to order, and Mumu really wanted to drink iced Coke, but because she had just had an upset stomach yesterday, Liang Shi refused to buy it for her no matter what. After getting their food, she walked toward their table.

Mumu stood there pouting, looking at her back with an aggrieved expression.

Liang Shi hardened her heart and ignored her anger, not even turning back to look, afraid she would go soft.

And so, in full view of everyone, in a KFC that was almost completely full, Shen Xuan stood in the middle of the restaurant and loudly shouted: "Grandma!"

Liang Shi: "?"

In that instant, Liang Shi felt everyone's eyes on her.

That day, Liang Shi was wearing a sky-blue fitted T-shirt, high-waisted jeans, with straightened hair, and had even dyed it a bit blue for an upcoming variety show—a blue-black color—and was wearing silver earrings.

Although she was wearing a mask, anyone could see she looked like she was just in her early twenties.

But Shen Xuan, as if afraid people didn't know, trotted a few steps over to tug at Liang Shi's hem, acting cute with an aggrieved expression: "Grandma~ just buy it for me!"

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi looked toward Xu Qingzhu, only to see Xu Qingzhu immediately lower her head, pretending to drink her Coke.

But in that moment, Liang Shi saw it.

Xu Qingzhu was secretly laughing!

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1. In China, all media content must pass government censorship review (过审, guò shěn) before being published or broadcast. Content touching on sensitive social or political issues often faces difficulty getting approved. ↩
 2. "视后" (shì hòu) literally means "TV Queen" and refers to winning the Best Actress award at major television award ceremonies. It's the television equivalent of winning Best Actress at film awards. ↩